

Utha USA — Community Money Guide

How Bangladeshi community organizations in the USA collect, use, and protect money — explained in simple words.

1. The organizations we studied

There are more than 100 Bangladeshi and Bengali community organizations in the USA. We studied about 28 of them closely — their websites, their fees, and their official tax records. Here are the most useful examples:

Organization	City	Member fee	How people pay	Money per year
Bangladesh Society Inc. (est. 1975)	New York	\$10/yr · \$500 lifetime	Cash, Zelle, card portal	\$190k–\$590k
BASGH	Houston	\$25–50/yr · \$150–250 life	Zelle, PayPal, website	\$91k–\$282k
BADFW	Dallas	not published	Zeffy (card, no fee)	\$210k–\$295k
BEST	Dallas–Fort Worth	\$100 / 2 years	Zelle, check, ticket site	not public
Saikat (est. 1987)	San Diego	\$80–275/yr	Zelle, PayPal, check	~\$328k
BAGA Atlanta	Atlanta	\$100–360/yr	Card, Zelle, cash, check, Square	~\$222k
Poorba	Bay Area, CA	\$200–650/yr	PayPal, Zelle, check	not public
BAM	Michigan	\$30–50/yr · \$500 life	website	under \$50k
BACA	Bronx, NY	\$20/yr · \$200 life	in person	small
CAB (Banga Sammelan host)	New York	\$250 life only	Zelle, check, card	up to \$1.09M in a convention year
BMANA (doctors' association)	National	\$150 / 2 yrs · \$500 life	Check, bank transfer	\$210k–\$240k
BDesh Foundation (charity)	Virginia	no members — donations	Website, check, Zelle, apps	~\$1.4M

Money-per-year numbers come from official IRS filings (Form 990) — public for any US nonprofit. Orgs earning under \$50k/year only file a short postcard, so their numbers stay private.

2. Where the money comes from — 4 sources

1. Membership fees. People pay every year to be a member. Cheap orgs charge \$10–50 per year. Premium orgs charge \$180–650 per year, but membership includes free entry to all big events with meals. Most orgs also sell a lifetime membership (\$150–500, pay once). Members get one big extra: **the right to vote** in the organization's elections.

2. Event tickets. Mela (fair) tickets are \$10–20. Big multi-day events cost more (Dallas charges \$170 for a 3-day Durga Puja pass with 6 meals). The biggest street fairs are often free — sponsors pay for them.

3. Sponsors. Local businesses (realtors, restaurants, travel agencies) pay to put their name on the event. Small events: \$500–5,000 per sponsor. Big national conventions: \$1,500 up to \$50,000. Sponsors get their logo on the stage, ads in the souvenir magazine, and a stall.

4. Donations and stall fees. General donations, special funds (scholarships, disaster relief, zakat), and fees that food/clothing vendors pay for a stall at the mela.

3. What happens when a person pays (the front side)

When you click a "Pay" or "Buy Ticket" button on these websites, one of three things happens:

Way A — The Zelle way (most common, \$0 cost)

Step 1: You fill a Google Form: your name, family members, phone, email.

Step 2: The website shows instructions: "Send Zelle to *treasurer@org-name.org*. Write your name + event in the note." You open your own banking app and send the money.

Step 3: The treasurer sees the money arrive, matches it with your form, and marks you paid in a spreadsheet.

Step 4: You get a confirmation by email or WhatsApp — sometimes after a few days. At the event, a volunteer finds your name on a list at the door.

Way B — Online checkout (modern way)

Step 1: You click the button and a card payment page opens (Zeffy, Square, Stripe, or PayPal).

Step 2: You choose your ticket or membership, type your card number, and pay.

Step 3: An e-ticket and receipt arrive in your email **instantly**. The organization's member list updates automatically — no human work needed.

Way C — At the gate (cash)

You pay cash at the event door. Usually a little more expensive than online (\$15 at the gate vs \$10 online) — this pushes people to pay online. You get a wristband or hand-stamp.

4. Behind the scenes — how the organization receives the money

First, the setup (done one time)

Before collecting a single dollar, a proper organization: **(1)** registers as a company in its state → **(2)** gets a tax ID number (EIN) from the IRS → **(3)** gets official nonprofit status (called 501(c)(3) — this makes donations tax-deductible) → **(4)** opens a **bank account in the organization's name**, with the president and treasurer as the authorized signers. Every payment method connects to this one bank account.

Warning sign: if an org says "send Zelle to my personal phone number or Gmail," the money is going into a person's private account, not the organization's. This mixing of money is how most community disputes start.

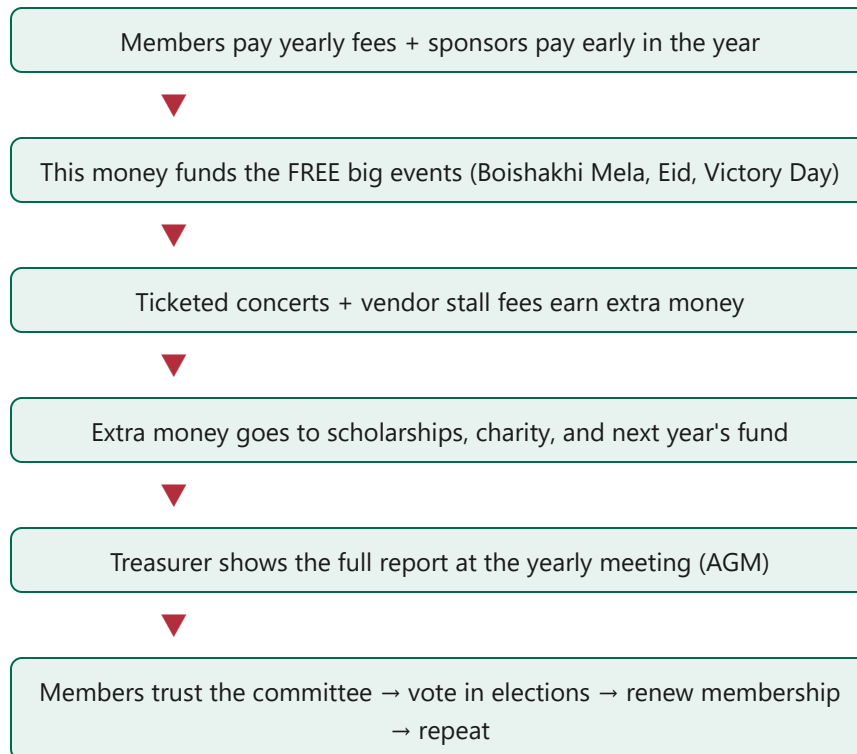
How the money travels, by method

Method	Where money goes first	Fee	Reaches org bank	Important to know
Zelle	Straight into the org's bank	\$0	Minutes	Cannot be refunded; treasurer must match payments to names by hand
PayPal	Sits in a PayPal balance first	~2%	1 day after treasurer withdraws	PayPal can freeze the account if a big event brings sudden money
Zeffy	Payment processor	\$0 (payers may tip Zeffy)	Auto-deposit on schedule	Builds the member list and tax receipts automatically — best free option
Square / Stripe	Payment processor	~3%	1–2 days, automatic	The dashboard becomes the bookkeeping
Ticket websites	The ticket site keeps it	Commission	5–7 days AFTER the event	The org must pay for the venue and artists first — sponsor money is what makes the event possible
Cash / checks	Cash box at the gate	\$0	When deposited	Counted by 2–3 people together, never one person alone

Then, the treasurer's job

- Keep a ledger (spreadsheet or QuickBooks): every dollar in is labeled (membership / ticket / sponsor / donation), every dollar out has a receipt.
- Volunteers who buy food or supplies with their own money submit receipts and get paid back from the org account.
- Every month: compare the ledger with the bank statement.
- Every year: present the full money report at the Annual General Meeting (AGM), and file the yearly IRS form (Form 990).
- Donors who give \$250 or more get a thank-you letter — the IRS requires it for their tax deduction.

5. The money cycle — one full year



6. Rules that keep the money safe

- **Bank account in the org's name only** — never a personal account.
- **Two signatures** for big payments; the treasurer and president are different people.
- **Count cash together** — 2–3 people, with a signed count sheet.
- **Show the numbers** — a yearly report to members builds trust; hiding numbers destroys it.
- **Hand over properly** — after every election, the bank signing power formally moves to the new treasurer. When leaders refuse this handover, organizations split into rival groups (this is what happened to FOBANA — it now has competing factions with separate websites).

7. What Utha USA should do (our recommendation)

Start simple, upgrade later:

- **Day 1 (costs \$0):** Google Form + Zelle to an official org email + one spreadsheet. This is exactly how most successful orgs run today.
- **Step 2:** Add a free Zeffy page for card payments — people get instant tickets and tax receipts, and the member list builds itself.
- **Membership:** keep it simple at first — for example Individual \$20/yr, Family \$40/yr, Lifetime \$200 (final prices are your decision).
- **Sponsors:** publish a clear sponsor package with prices (for example \$500 / \$1,000 / \$2,500). Almost no org does this openly — being transparent will make Utha USA stand out.
- **Trust:** put the committee names, the treasurer's contact, and a simple yearly money summary on the website. Transparency is the cheapest way to grow a community organization.

8. What if we don't want to register anything?

You can still run the community — it is then called an **informal club** (legally: "unincorporated association"). Many Bangladeshi groups run for years this way. But know the limits:

Works fine without registration

- The website itself — events, photos, committee, contact. No registration ever needed.
- Free events (picnics, iftars) and collecting money per event the traditional *chaanda* way: "\$18 per family, Zelle to [one trusted person]" — exact cost, spent fully on the event.
- Ticketed events through Eventbrite or desi ticket sites (an individual person can be the organizer).
- Free membership — people just join the member list (like BAGA Austin does).

NOT possible without registration

- No bank account in the group's name — all money passes through **a person's private account**, and payment apps report big amounts to the IRS as that person's income.
- Never say "tax-deductible donation" — that claim is only legal with 501(c)(3) status. Say "contribution" or "event fee."
- No protection if something goes wrong at an event — organizers are personally responsible.
- No Zeffy or org PayPal account; sponsors usually want to pay an organization, not a person.

The three real options

A. Informal club + public ledger (start here): one trusted collector, per-event Zelle, and a shared Google Sheet where **every dollar in and out is visible to all members**. Openness replaces legal structure as the source of trust. Keep amounts small; keep no big balance in anyone's personal account.

B. Use an umbrella (fiscal sponsorship): an already-registered organization — an established association, a mosque, or a fiscal-sponsor platform — receives your money under *their* registration for a small fee (~5–8%). You get a real bank account and tax-deductible donations with zero registration of your own.

C. The tiny middle step: an EIN (tax ID) from the IRS website is **free, takes 15 minutes**, and an informal club can get one and open a bank account with it — no state registration needed. This removes the biggest danger (money in personal accounts). Full 501(c)(3) later costs about \$275–400 one time.

Recommendation: start with A plus the public-ledger rule from day one. The moment regular membership money starts coming in, take step C (the free EIN) so money stops living in someone's personal Zelle. The website works the same in all three options — only the payment page wording changes.

9. Making it automatic — the Utha USA automation plan

Zelle itself cannot be automated (it has no computer connection). But **everything around the payment can be** — so the treasurer's whole job becomes one click per payment. Here is what the automated system looks like:

What each person experiences

A member (100% automatic): clicks Join → fills the form → screen shows "Send \$40 by Zelle to [collector], write **UTHA-1052** in the note" → sends Zelle from their bank app → automatically receives a receipt + a digital member card with a QR code → gets renewal reminder emails next year by itself. For events: click Attend → QR e-ticket by email → show the phone at the door.

The treasurer (one click): opens the private admin page → sees "Pending: UTHA-1052 — Rahim — Family \$40" → checks the bank app → clicks **Confirm**. That click automatically sends the receipt and member card, updates the member list, and adds the public ledger entry. The dashboard shows totals by category — the yearly report writes itself.

The door volunteer: opens the scanner page on a phone → scans each QR code → green ✓ valid, red X expired → live guest count. No paper.

Nobody (fully automatic): welcome emails, receipts, member cards, renewal reminders, automatic expiry of unpaid members, event reminders, the public transparency ledger.

The five parts of the machine

- **Website** — pages everyone sees (home, events, join, public ledger)
- **Database** — members, payments, events, tickets
- **Email robot** — every confirmation and reminder
- **Admin dashboard** — the treasurer's pending list and Confirm button
- **QR system** — member cards, e-tickets, and the phone scanner page

The whole picture with NO registration at all — the three doors

Everything that is not money (website, database, member cards, reminders, QR check-in, public ledger) needs no registration and automates 100%. The money itself can only enter through three doors:

Door	How it works	Automation	Who already does it
1. Zelle + code + Confirm click	Payer writes a reference code (UTHA-1052) in the Zelle note; treasurer clicks Confirm once; receipt, card, list, ledger fire automatically	95%, \$0 fee	BEST Dallas (memberships, picnic), BCS Cleveland, Facebook <i>desher bari</i> societies
2. Ticket marketplace (Eventbrite, desieventsgo, Sulekha)	An individual person creates the event; cards, e-tickets, attendee list and scanner all handled by the marketplace; money never sits in a personal account — one traceable payout after the event	100% for events	BEST's Boishakhi Mela (desieventsgo), Poorba's Dandiya (Sulekha), many desi promoters on Eventbrite
3. One person's own Stripe/Square/PayPal	Opened with a person's SSN; even membership renewals charge themselves; but all money legally counts as that person's income — needs clean records at tax time	100% for everything	Small clubs across America; open this door last

The no-registration blueprint: memberships through Door 1 · event tickets (the big money) through Door 2 · Door 3 only if ever needed. House rules: never write "tax-deductible" (say *contribution* or *event fee*), spend money on events as it comes so no big balance lives in a personal account, and let the public ledger show every dollar — openness replaces registration as the reason people trust you.

Cost and upgrade path

Running cost can be **\$0/month** on free hosting and database tiers — the only real cost is the domain name (~\$12/year). If Utha USA ever changes its mind and gets the free EIN and an organization bank account, Stripe or Zeffy plugs into the same website: card payments confirm themselves, the treasurer's Confirm click disappears, and nothing else needs rebuilding.

Prepared for the Utha USA community website project · August 2026 · Sources: organization websites and public IRS Form 990 filings (ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer). Full details with all links: [docs/research-bangladeshi-community-orgs-usa.md](#) and [docs/money-systems-by-organization.md](#).